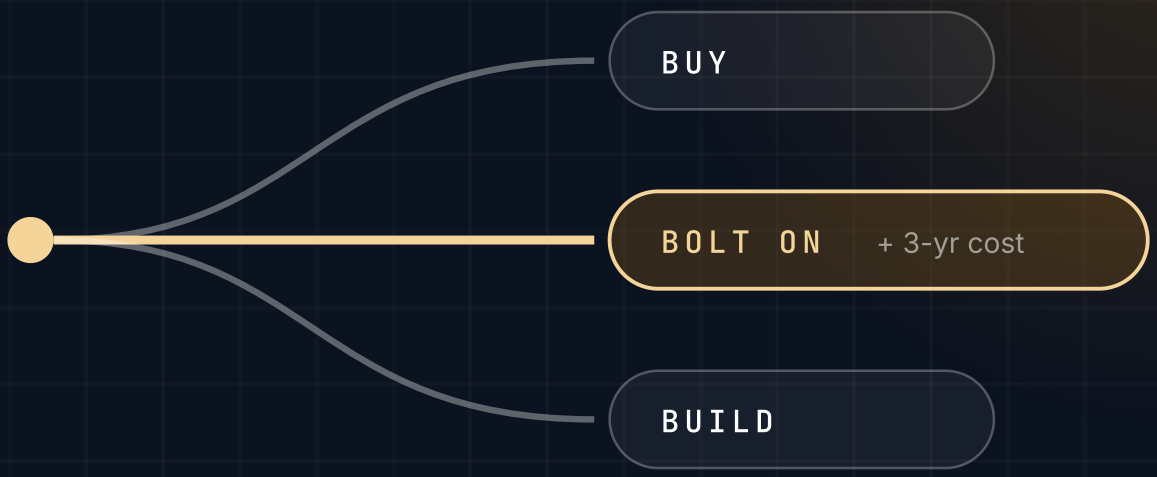
11-MINUTE READ · 1 WORKSHEET

Build, buy *or bolt on?*

The 3-year cost worksheet for choosing between off-the-shelf software, a custom app, or the smart middle path.



THE QUIET CREEP

Subscriptions feel cheap. *Until you add them up.*

$29 a user here, $49 there. Each tool made sense on the day you signed up. Three years later you're paying for a dozen of them, half the seats sit empty, prices rise every renewal, and your team still copies data between them by hand.

$4,830

average SaaS spend per employee in 2024, up 21.9% in a year.

ZYLO SAAS MANAGEMENT INDEX 2025 [1]

12.3%

rise in SaaS prices in 2024, against 2.7% average inflation in G7 countries.

VERTICE SAAS INFLATION INDEX [2]

46%

of software licences go unused on average, according to the same type of spend analysis.

ZYLO, 2026 INDEX [1]

A fair warning about these numbers: they come from companies that sell software-spend tools, and they lean towards larger organisations. Your figures will differ. That's exactly why this guide gives you a worksheet instead of a verdict.

Off-the-shelf is often the right answer

This isn't a "build everything" guide. Nobody should write their own accounting system, payroll or email. Good software you can rent is one of the best deals in business. The trouble starts when you rent tools for the part of your business that makes you *different*, or when you need five subscriptions plus a person copying between them to do one job.

In this guide

The three paths (page 3) · the 8-question decision test (page 4) · the 3-year cost worksheet (page 5) · a worked example where the answer flips with the number of users (page 6) · hidden costs on both sides (page 7) · five bolt-ons that pay off fast (page 8).

THREE PATHS

It's rarely build *or* buy. *Usually it's both.*

BUY

Rent a ready-made tool

A subscription (SaaS) that works on day one.

Best for: standard processes everyone has: accounting, payroll, email, e-signatures, video calls, basic scheduling.

BOLT ON

Keep the tool, add the missing piece

A small custom app or connection around software you already pay for.

Best for: when a tool does 80% of the job and your team fills the last 20% by hand: a portal, a form, an approval step, a report.

BUILD

Own something made for you

A custom app that fits your process exactly.

Best for: the way you win customers, workflows no product covers, or when per-user prices punish your growth.

> Buy what makes you the same as everyone else. Build what makes you different.

Ask: **if a competitor copied this tool tomorrow, would it matter?** If no, buy it. If yes (your quoting method, your customer experience, your scheduling logic), it's a candidate for building, or at least bolting on.

Signs you're on the wrong path today

- ✕ You pay for features you'll never use to get the one you need.
- ✕ Your team keeps a spreadsheet *next to* the tool you bought.
- ✕ Every new hire costs another seat on four products.
- ✕ "The software doesn't let us do that" shapes how you serve customers.
- ✕ You've built something custom that a $20 tool already does well.
- ✕ Nobody can say how many subscriptions you pay for.

THE DECISION TEST

Eight questions. *Tick a column for each.*

QUESTION	POINTS TO BUY	POINTS TO BOLT ON	POINTS TO BUILD
1. Is this how you win customers?	No, it's standard.	Partly.	Yes, it's our edge.
2. Does a good product already do 80%+?	Yes, almost all.	Yes, with gaps we fill by hand.	No, we'd bend our process.
3. How many users in three years?	A handful.	Growing, but a few power users.	Many, and per-seat prices add up.
4. How many tools for this one job?	One.	Two or three, glued by hand.	Four or more, plus spreadsheets.
5. How often does the process change?	Rarely.	A few tweaks a year.	Often, because we keep improving it.
6. Where must the data live?	Vendor's terms are fine.	Mostly fine; sensitive part kept separate.	Canada or our own control, no exceptions.
7. Who will look after it?	Nobody; we need zero upkeep.	Someone light-touch.	A care plan or in-house person.
8. When do you need it?	This month.	In a few weeks.	In a few months is fine.
Your ticks per column	_____	_____	_____

Reading the result

The column with the most ticks is your starting point, not your answer. Questions 1 and 2 count double. Then check it against the cost worksheet: if the numbers disagree with your instinct, trust the numbers and look for what you missed.

Never build these

Accounting, payroll, email, video calls, e-signatures, card payments processing. Rent the best and connect it. A custom app should *talk to* these, not replace them.

WORKSHEET · 3-YEAR COST

Compare *three years, not three months.*

Subscriptions look cheap in month one; custom work looks expensive in month one. Over three years the picture can reverse. Fill in what applies; leave the rest blank.

COST LINE (3 YEARS)	BUY	BOLT ON	BUILD
Subscriptions: price per user per month × users × 12, for each year. Add your expected yearly price rise (8 to 12% is common lately).			
Set-up: onboarding, configuration, importing your data.			
Connectors: Zapier-style tools, paid add-ons, API plans.			
Workarounds: hours a week of manual copying because the tool doesn't fit × hourly cost × 48 × 3.			
Custom work: the fixed quote for the build or the bolt-on.			
Running costs: hosting and services per month × 36.			
Care and maintenance: commonly 15 to 20% of the custom work per year, after the first year.			
Improvements: changes you already expect in years 2 and 3.			
Training and switching: time to learn the new way of working.			
3-year total			

Don't forget the value side. Money is only half the story: a tool that answers customers faster or prevents one lost contract a year may be worth more than everything on this page.

Get real numbers. For "Buy", use list prices for the plan you'd actually need (not the cheapest). For "Build" and "Bolt on", ask for a fixed quote based on a one-page brief (guide 02).

WORKED EXAMPLE

Same business, two sizes. *Two different winners.*

A fictional home-services company schedules jobs, sends quotes and tracks crews. The off-the-shelf option is a field-service platform at $45 per user per month, rising 10% a year. The team spends about 3 hours a week working around it. The bolt-on is a $9,000 custom add-on that removes the workarounds. The build is a $28,000 custom app.

WITH 30 USERS	BUY	BOLT ON	BUILD
Subscriptions (y1 $16,200 · y2 $17,820 · y3 $19,602)	$53,622	$53,622	–
Set-up and data import	$3,000	$3,000	incl.
Connectors ($50/month)	$1,800	–	–
Workarounds (3 h/week × $40 × 48 × 3)	$17,280	–	–
Custom work (fixed quote)	–	$9,000	$28,000
Running costs ($30 or $80/month × 36)	–	$1,080	$2,880
Care, years 2 and 3 (15% a year)	–	$2,700	$8,400
Improvements and training	–	–	$7,000
3-year total, 30 users	**$75,702**	**$69,402**	**$46,280**

NOW THE SAME WITH 8 USERS	BUY	BOLT ON	BUILD
Subscriptions (y1 $4,320 · y2 $4,752 · y3 $5,227)	$14,299	$14,299	–
Everything else (unchanged)	$22,080	$15,780	$46,280
3-year total, 8 users	**$36,379**	**$30,079**	**$46,280**

The lesson: per-seat pricing and workaround hours decide most of these choices. At 8 users, keep the product and bolt on the missing piece. At 30, owning the tool wins by a wide margin. Run your own numbers: they'll tell you which business you are.

HIDDEN COSTS

Every path has a catch. *Here's how to defuse it.*

Buying: the catches

- ✕ **Price rises at renewal**, often well above inflation.
- ✕ **Features move to a pricier tier** after you depend on them.
- ✕ **Seats creep**: people leave, licences stay.
- ✕ **Lock-in**: your history is hard to export in a useful form.
- ✕ **Your process bends** to fit the tool, and customers feel it.

Defuse: cap yearly increases in the contract; audit seats every quarter; test a full data export *before* you sign; keep a list of every subscription with an owner.

Building: the catches

- ✕ **Upkeep never ends**: security updates, hosting, small fixes.
- ✕ **Dependence on a vendor** who knows the code.
- ✕ **Decisions land on you**: there's no product team deciding for you.
- ✕ **Time to value**: weeks, not minutes.
- ✕ **Scope creep**: "while we're at it..."

Defuse: own the code and accounts in your name; insist on documentation; agree a fixed-price care plan; start with the smallest version that works; keep a Later list (guide 02).

The question that cuts through both

"If we had to walk away in three years, what would we take with us?" With a rented product: your data, if the export is good. With a custom app you own: the code, the data and everything you learned. Ask it of every option on the table.

THE BOLT-ON PLAYBOOK

Five bolt-ons *that pay off fast.*

The middle path is underrated. Keep the software that works and add the one piece your team fills in by hand.

BOLT-ON	YOU NEED IT WHEN…	WHAT CHANGES
1. Customer portal	Customers email or call to ask about status, documents or invoices.	They look it up themselves, 24/7, in their language.
2. Smart intake form	Requests arrive by email and someone re-types them into your system.	Clean data flows straight in, with required fields and rules.
3. One dashboard	Monday starts with exporting from three tools to see where you stand.	The numbers you check every week, on one screen, always current.
4. Approval workflow	Quotes, expenses or time off are approved by "reply all".	One button, a clear trail of who approved what, and reminders.
5. Automatic report	Someone builds the same PDF or spreadsheet every week or month.	It arrives in the right inboxes on schedule, already formatted.

Before you buy your next subscription

- [ ] Count the users you'll have in three years, not today.
- [ ] Find the plan you'll *actually* need, and its price after the first-year discount.
- [ ] Ask how to export everything, then try it during the trial.
- [ ] Write down the gap: what will still be done by hand? Price that gap.

SOURCES

1. Zylo, "2025 SaaS Management Index" (press release, 16 January 2025): average SaaS spend $4,830 per employee, +21.9% year over year. Zylo's 2026 index reports 46% of licences unused on average. Zylo sells SaaS-management software; its data covers mostly mid-size and large organisations.
2. Vertice, "SaaS Inflation Index" (2025 edition): SaaS prices up 12.3% in 2024 versus 2.7% average G7 market inflation. Vertice sells software-procurement services.
3. The worked example and the 15 to 20% yearly care figure are illustrations and a common industry rule of thumb, not quotes. Example prices are in Canadian dollars; the Zylo figures are in US dollars.

Addanapp

FROM THE TEAM AT ADDANAPP.COM

Know what you need? *We'll tell you what it costs.*

Addanapp is a Montréal software studio. We build business apps, portals, back-offices and integrations at AI speed, and a senior engineer signs off every change before it reaches you.

A fixed price first
Every request is quoted before work starts. Nothing starts until you approve.

No acceptance, no invoice
You test it on a staging version. If it doesn't meet the criteria, we fix it at no extra cost.

Human-validated
AI drafts, engineers decide. Line-by-line review, tests and security checks on every change.

You own everything
Code, data and accounts are yours from day one. Built with Law 25 and PIPEDA in mind.

Send a short brief (the template in guide 02 is perfect) and an engineer, not a salesperson, will reply with questions or a fixed quote.

addanapp.com →

THE FREE GUIDE SERIES

01 Your Spreadsheet Is Already an App
02 The One-Page App Brief
03 AI-Built, Human-Signed
04 **Build, Buy or Bolt On**
05 Law 25 for Your Next App

© 2026 Addanapp. Edition 1 · November 2026. You're welcome to share this PDF unchanged. General information only, not legal, tax or financial advice: check the specifics of your situation with a qualified professional. Figures cited were accurate to their sources at the time of writing; see the Sources section. Company names in examples are fictional unless a source is cited.